

Reading a mastery score

Across a cohort, a Canvas outcome number is a *pass rate* – the share of students who cleared the mastery line – *not* the average grade on an assignment. Keep these two numbers separate and you will not misreport.

1 The one thing to remember

“It’s a pass rate, not a score. It tells you who cleared the bar, not how high anyone jumped.”

Cohort (threshold = 70)	Raw scores	Point average	Mastery “average”
A — all just over	71, 72, 70, 71, 73	71.4%	100%
B — all well over	70, 100, 100, 95, 98	92.6%	100%
C — all just under	69, 68, 69, 67, 69	68.4%	0%

A and B are **identical** in the mastery gradebook (100%) but 21 points apart in reality. And **three points** of raw difference flips A to C — from 100% to 0% — because everyone sits right on the bar. The mastery number is deliberately blind to distance from the line.

2 Fill in your own results

If you used AVERAGE

For _____ [outcome], each student’s mastery score is the average of _____ aligned scores. A student reaches mastery at _____ or above. _____ % of _____ students reached mastery. This is a **pass rate, not an average score.**

If you used DECAYING AVERAGE (35 / 65)

For _____ [outcome], each student’s mastery score weights their most recent score at 65% and earlier scores at 35% combined. A student reaches mastery at _____ or above. _____ % of _____ students reached mastery. This is a **recency-weighted pass rate**, not an average of raw scores.

3 Word it correctly

DON’T SAY

Students averaged 80% on research literacy. (*Nobody scored 80 — that’s the fraction who passed.*)

SAY INSTEAD

80% of students reached the mastery threshold for research literacy.

Before you trust a trend: when scores cluster near the bar, or the group is small (under ~10), a tiny shift in raw work swings the pass rate. Read it next to the raw distribution.